

CHAPTER 5

THIRTY HOURS

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It was 3 December 1994. By now I had been standing for more than thirty hours, without food or water. Just when I thought that the last of the devils had gone, a bald man walked in. He looked dignified, but by now I was wary of anyone who came to me.

'Take your seat,' he said.

'I don't deserve a seat.'

'So you admit you are guilty?'

'I don't deserve a seat—that's what your guys say.'

He offered me water, but I refused.

'Are you on a *satyagraha*?' he said. That is when I realised that what I am doing was indeed *satyagraha*. Sensing how my refusal of water and a seat after a day and night of torture scared some of them, I felt the power of *satyagraha*. Till then I was never a fan of Mahatma Gandhi, I have even felt how useless non-violent defiance was in the face of the high and mighty. Now I realised how wrong I was, and how potent this truth-driven, non-violent, non-cooperation was.

'How long will you stand?'

'As long as my legs permit me.'

Something told me that this man was not from IB, and could probably be from R&AW, the external intelligence agency. He turned to one of the IB